

AWAKENING

Design Document for an Opening Cutscene

GAME 326 — Cinematography for Games
Midterm Assignment | Subject 2 — Option 2

1. Introduction

1.1 Game Concept

Awakening is a first-person psychological science-fiction horror game set within the corridors of a clandestine subterranean research facility. Its atmosphere is constructed on the tension between sterile institutional coldness and the residue of abandonment: the laboratory is simultaneously functional and forsaken. Generically, the project situates itself within the lineage of titles such as SOMA (Frictional Games, 2015), Observer (Bloober Team, 2017), and Alien: Isolation (Creative Assembly, 2014), privileging slow-accreting dread and the existential unease of fragmented memory over high-intensity action sequences.

The protagonist is a test subject with no recollection of their identity. The facility itself functions as both setting and antagonist; as the player progresses, inscriptions on walls, abandoned gurneys, failing fluorescent lights, and red emergency signals gradually disclose fragments of the character's history. The visual idiom is deliberately minimalist: dialogue is almost entirely absent, and narrative meaning is generated through environment, illumination, and camera behaviour rather than verbal exposition.

1.2 The Scene's Role

This opening cutscene anchors the player to the diegetic world through three foundational questions: Who am I? Where is this? What happened to me? The sequence is not designed to answer these questions but to implant them. The narrative hook emerges from fragmented traumatic memory imagery, while the mechanical hook is delivered by the concluding wide shot, which organically prepares the player for the transfer of control.

The cutscene is condensed into sixty seconds. This brevity serves a dual function: it avoids exhausting the player's patience while maintaining atmospheric density, and it prevents the loss of narrative momentum in the transition to gameplay.

2. Technical Design — Application of the 5Cs

2.1 Camera Angles and Movement

The cutscene is composed of five distinct camera setups and a concluding montage of six rapid flash cuts. Each angle carries a deliberate psychological function and evolves in parallel with the character's fluctuating state of consciousness.

- **Shot 1 — Extreme Close-up (eyes):** A 100 mm focal length paired with an aperture of f/1.4 produces an aggressively shallow depth of field. The frame envelops the character's eyes, admitting the player into the scene through the protagonist's subjective consciousness. This composition constitutes a deliberate reworking of the intimate opening tradition exemplified by the ocular sequence of *Blade Runner 2049* (Villeneuve, 2017).
- **Shot 2 — Dolly Out (reveal):** The camera recedes slowly from above the character, employing a 35 mm focal length at f/2.8. The movement articulates the spatial relationship between figure and environment: the smaller the character becomes within the frame, the more oppressive the facility grows around them. The technique draws on the disempowering slow reveal familiar from Stanley Kubrick's compositional vocabulary.
- **Shot 3 — POV (subjective perspective):** A 24 mm wide-angle lens captures the surgical light fixture from the character's point of view, directed upward at the ceiling. The focus distance is animated from blurred to sharp (Manual Focus: 5 → 300), simulating the character's return to sensory awareness. A subtle handheld-style oscillation reinforces corporeal vulnerability.
- **Shot 4 — Static Observational (corridor):** An environmental composition shot at 24 mm, f/1.8. The camera advances imperceptibly forward (approximately 1.5 metres over ten seconds). This shot intentionally excludes the character, positioning the environment itself as the locus of threat. The near-subliminal forward motion generates an unconscious sensation of encroachment.
- **Shot 5 — High Wide (closing establishing shot):** An 18 mm ultra-wide angle captured from an elevated position approximating a high-angle perspective. The character occupies the frame as a diminished silhouette; the environment overwhelms them. This terminal composition functions as the *establishing shot* preparing the transition to player agency.

2.2 Composition and Lighting

The Rule of Thirds is applied systematically throughout the sequence. In Shot 1, the eyes are aligned along the upper horizontal third; in Shot 3, the surgical lamp is positioned at the upper intersection point; and in Shot 5, the character occupies the right vertical third. These placements operate on the viewer's ocular attention at a pre-reflective level, guiding the gaze without announcing the compositional logic.

Shallow depth of field is deliberately exploited in Shots 1, 3, and 4. The f/1.4 aperture of Shot 1 in particular blurs everything behind the ocular plane, confining the viewer to the protagonist's immediate phenomenal field.

The lighting design follows a single-source, motivated-lighting approach. In Shot 4, a lone fluorescent fixture (a RectLight at 6500 K cool white) executes a mechanical failure pattern. Its intensity is modulated between 0 and 110 across more than twenty keyframes using Constant interpolation. The deliberate irregularity of this pattern thwarts the brain's pattern-

recognition instinct and generates a sustained, low-grade disquiet. In Shot 5, a red Point Light (intensity ramped smoothly from 0 to 80) visualises the alarm metaphor and saturates the corridor in crimson tones. A Post Process Volume introduces subtle Bloom (0.3), reduced saturation (0.75), pronounced vignette (0.4), and mild chromatic aberration (0.5), rendering the image closer to filmic aesthetics.

2.3 Cutting and Pacing

The rhythmic architecture of the cutscene is organised into three distinct movements. The first movement (0–28 seconds) proceeds slowly and meditatively, connected by soft fade transitions, allowing the player to acclimate while the character awakens. The second movement (28–40 seconds) sustains the corridor shot in stillness; this silence operates as the charge preceding the subsequent discharge. The third movement (40–60 seconds) accelerates abruptly into a staccato climax.

The flash montage in the final ten seconds constitutes an applied instance of Sergei Eisenstein's theory of collision montage (Eisenstein, 1949). Six discrete flashes, each lasting two to four frames, collide against one another through rapid intervals of black. The cameras cycle through Cam_CloseUp (white burst), Cam_POV, Cam_DollyOut, Cam_CloseUp (mega flash), Cam_Corridor, and a culminating Cam_CloseUp. This sequencing visually reconstructs the character's fractured memory.

Exposure manipulation, executed through the Post Process Volume's Exposure Compensation parameter (ranging from 0 to 15), produces the white flash effect. All flash keyframes employ Constant interpolation; no easing occurs, only abrupt cuts. This generates a neurological-shock-like response in the viewer. The transition between Shot 4 and Shot 5 is deliberately constructed as a smash cut rather than a fade, because the introduction of the red alarm must arrive without preparation.

2.4 Continuity and Close-ups

The 180-degree rule is preserved across all transitions. Shots 1, 2, 3, and 5 share a common axis grounded on the character's body, preserving the viewer's spatial orientation. Shot 4, lacking a human subject, does not introduce axial displacement.

An eyeline match is established between Shots 1 and 3: the protagonist's gaze is directed upward in Shot 1, and Shot 3 reveals the object of that gaze, the surgical lamp. This structure produces a match cut dynamic and inserts the player directly into the character's subjective experience.

Close-ups are deployed strategically in three locations to intensify emotional resonance and foreground texture: the opening ocular shot (personal intimacy), the POV surgical lamp (external threat and interrogative connotation), and the recurring ocular flashes within the montage (the visual figure of trauma). Fade-to-black transitions function as markers of temporal continuity, each representing a lapse in consciousness that aligns with the character's memory gaps.

2.5 Sound Design

The sound design is organised around a three-layer architecture that deliberately eschews vocal elements (screams, dialogue, or human vocalisations) in favour of non-diegetic cinematic impacts and low-frequency atmospheric textures. This choice preserves the sterile, technological coldness of the facility and avoids the organic warmth that vocal sounds would introduce. The soundscape is constructed to emanate from the facility itself rather than from any identifiable human source, reinforcing the proposition that the environment, not any antagonist, is the principal threat.

The first layer comprises continuous atmospheric sources. A low-frequency fluorescent hum and a sub-bass drone begin subtly during Shot 1 and swell throughout the sequence. During Shots 1 and 2, a slow, rhythmic heartbeat and muted respiratory sounds introduce the only biological elements of the entire soundscape, anchoring the viewer within the character's body without ever permitting that body to vocalise. The corridor sequence (Shot 4) is marked by a pronounced drop in acoustic energy, generating the oppressive silence that functions as the dramatic charge preceding the final discharge.

The second layer consists of diegetic environmental sources. Subtle gurney creaks and metallic cable shifts accompany the dolly out in Shot 2; faint monitor beeps sustain the clinical register in Shot 3; and the fluorescent flicker in Shot 4 is synchronised with brief electrical crackles and buzz artefacts that reinforce the image of mechanical failure. These diegetic sources remain sparse throughout; the soundscape privileges absence over density.

The third layer, and the most rhetorically charged, is non-diegetic. Each of the six flashes within the concluding montage is punctuated by a deep cinematic bass impact — a single low-frequency hit in the tradition of contemporary trailer sound design (cf. the braam-inflected idiom popularised in the wake of *Inception* (Nolan, 2010)). These impacts are spaced irregularly, tracking the visual rhythm of the montage, and they increase in intensity across the sequence, reaching their acoustic apex on the final flash. A sustained sub-bass drone underlies the montage continuously, ensuring that the silences between impacts are never truly empty; the listener remains in a state of low-grade acoustic pressure that the bass hits periodically rupture. The final fade to black is accompanied by a terminal tail tone that decays to silence, closing the sequence without vocal punctuation.

The decision to construct the entire soundscape without human vocalisations is conceptually central to the design. Screams and dialogue would have externalised the character's suffering as an object for the player's empathy. The chosen soundscape instead keeps that suffering implicit and environmental: the trauma is heard as infrastructural noise, as alarm, as impact — never as voice. This formal restraint corresponds directly to the narrative premise of a character whose identity and memory have been stripped away; a voiceless character demands a voiceless sound design.

3. Narrative and Player Engagement

3.1 Dramatic Structure

The sequence condenses a classical three-act structure into sixty seconds. The Setup (0–20 s) introduces the character's awakening and the environment: eye, body, space. The player establishes orientation while questions accumulate. The Confrontation (20–45 s) generates tension through the corridor shot, where flicker, the abandoned gurney, and the unknown corridor materialise threat without rendering it concrete. The Resolution (45–60 s) reaches its detonation point through the flash montage, after which the concluding wide shot leaves the character alone with their unknown fate.

This structure performs a quiet inversion of genre convention. Whereas the conventional opening cutscene prepares the player for action, Awakening prepares the player for discomfort. The emotional arc traces a trajectory from unknowing through dread and shock to isolation.

3.2 Seamless Transition to Gameplay

The terminal composition (Shot 5) is deliberately optimised for the transfer of player agency. The wide, elevated framing reveals both character and environment in a single glance; the player apprehends where they stand, what lies ahead, and the state of their surroundings. The persistence of the red alarm also pre-announces the immediate gameplay objective (flee or investigate).

To ensure a seamless cutscene-to-gameplay transition, the character's final position is designed to correspond exactly with their initial gameplay position. When the player assumes control, the camera will likely shift to a first-person or tight third-person view; to render this transition frictionless, the final shot is already organised around a character-centric composition.

4. Conclusion and Critical Interpretation

4.1 Evaluation

Each cinematographic decision in this design supports a single thesis: that wordless narration is not merely possible but, under certain conditions, more communicative than its verbal counterpart. Camera angle, lighting colour, cutting rhythm, and acoustic texture — these four variables deliver more information about the character than any amount of expository dialogue could transmit. The extreme close-up produces intimacy; the dolly out constructs powerlessness; the POV establishes corporeal alignment; the static corridor shot isolates; and the wide terminal composition quarantines. The sound design, in its refusal of human vocalisation, amplifies this wordlessness from a cinematographic choice into an axiomatic commitment.

The choice of the flicker effect merits particular commentary. A mechanical malfunction operates simultaneously as a plausible detail of the facility and as a metaphor for the fragmented mind. It performs narrative, atmospheric, and stylistic functions in a single gesture.

The red alarm light similarly functions both diegetically, as an artefact of the facility, and symbolically, as an externalisation of psychic rupture. The bass impacts accompanying the final montage operate on a parallel register: they are simultaneously the sound of the facility's sirens, the sound of the character's interior rupture, and the conventional syntax of cinematic crisis.

The principal references informing this design include the opening sequences of SOMA (Frictional Games, 2015), the awakening sequence of Alien: Isolation (Creative Assembly, 2014), and the memory-dive sequences of Observer (Bloober Team, 2017). On the cinematic side, Stanley Kubrick's slow reveals in 2001: A Space Odyssey (1968), the subjective POV technique of Gaspar Noé's Enter the Void (2009), and the low-frequency sonic architecture popularised by Christopher Nolan and Hans Zimmer in Inception (2010) were taken as formal models.

4.2 Contribution to Storytelling

Visual language here does not substitute for dialogue but reaches where dialogue cannot. To narrate the character's trauma in a spoken line is to deliver it as information; to enact it through flash montage and bass impacts is to make the player undergo a proportionally reduced version of the same trauma. The 'show, don't tell' principle is radicalised: nothing is told, and everything is enacted. The absence of vocal elements in the sound design is not an omission but an affirmative compositional choice, asserting that the most affecting narrative register, in the context of memory loss and identity dissolution, is the one that refuses the voice.

The effect of this approach on the player experience is not empathy but proximity. The player is not invited to understand the character but to share in the same disorientation. This represents one of the most effective narrative strategies available to psychological horror: the equalisation of informational asymmetry between character and audience. Every fragment of knowledge the player subsequently uncovers will function as a simultaneous revelation for both parties.

In sum, this sixty-second cutscene does not attempt to tell a story; it constructs a mood. That mood constitutes the substantive narrative foundation upon which the remainder of the game is staged.

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